

AAG IT Change Management for Stability Presentation Q&A

1. Why is Change Management being emphasized so strongly right now?

IT Change Management is a **direct operational control** for the airline. Changes to technology affect flight operations, crews, guests, and airports. Recent operational impacts, combined with the upcoming **PSS milestone**, require tighter visibility, predictability, and risk management to protect airline stability.

2. Is this a permanent slowdown of delivery?

No. This is a **temporary, stability-first posture**. The intent is to reduce operational risk during a high-risk period, while building toward a future state that supports **faster, safer delivery through standardization and automation**.

3. What is considered a “Change”?

A change is **any action that adds, modifies, or removes anything that could directly or indirectly impact production**, including:

- Code deployments
- Configuration changes (e.g., DNS, feature flags)
- Infrastructure and cloud changes
- Database schema or data changes
- Vendor-initiated changes

If it can touch production or airline operations, it is a change.

4. Are “Informational” changes a valid change type?

No. The supported change types are:

- **Standard**
- **Normal**
- **Emergency**

If visibility is needed, the work should be logged under one of these types rather than creating an “informational” category.

5. Why are so many changes being classified as Medium or High risk?

The current **risk decision tree** prioritizes **operational impact and blast radius**, particularly for:

- Day-of-travel systems
- Guest-facing services with operational dependency
- Shared or foundational services

This conservative approach is intentional during the pre-PSS period. Refinements are actively being evaluated to better reflect mitigations and scope.

6. How does mitigation (testing, automation, monitoring) factor into risk?

Mitigations **do matter**, but today they are not fully reflected in tooling or scoring. This is a known gap. The future state is expected to better account for:

- Proven repeatability
 - Monitoring and detection
 - Rollback or fix-forward speed
 - Deployment safety controls
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7. Do all guest-facing changes require CAB?

Not all guest-facing changes are equal. The intent is to focus heightened scrutiny on **day-of-travel and operationally critical systems**. Clarifications are being incorporated into guidance and FAQs as definitions are refined.

8. What is a Standard Change?

A Standard Change is a **low-risk, repeatable, well-understood activity** with consistent success.

Standard does **not** mean “automated only.” Manual work can qualify if it is:

- Performed frequently
- Fully documented
- Proven safe over time

Standard Changes are the long-term mechanism to restore speed safely.

9. Can a change become a Standard Change over time?

Yes. Teams are encouraged to build toward Standard Changes by demonstrating repeatability, documentation quality, and operational safety. CAB and Change Management will help guide that progression.

10. Are runbooks required for every change?

Runbooks are required where they support **operational recovery**. They do not need to be perfect on day one. The expectation is:

- **Minimum viable runbooks first**
- Clear validation and recovery steps
- Iterative improvement over time

The goal is rapid recovery if something goes wrong, not documentation for documentation’s sake.

11. Do bug fixes require runbooks?

Yes, when they impact production systems. Even simple fixes should have enough documentation to support troubleshooting, validation, and recovery if needed.

12. Can runbooks and diagrams be linked instead of attached?

Yes. Links to SharePoint or other repositories are acceptable, especially for living documents. In some cases, attaching a snapshot may also be appropriate for audit and traceability.

13. What if a change has no rollback?

Some changes are **fail-forward by nature**. In those cases, teams should clearly document:

- Why rollback is not possible
 - How impact will be detected
 - How the system will be stabilized or fixed forward
 - Stop/go decision points
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14. How are Emergency Changes handled?

Emergency Changes are allowed when immediate action is required to restore service or prevent operational impact. They must still be documented and reviewed after implementation.

15. What is the weekly change submission deadline?

Changes scheduled for the upcoming week must be **submitted by Friday at 6:00 PM** (timezone as communicated in official guidance). This ensures inclusion in leadership visibility and CAB planning.

16. What needs to be complete by the Friday deadline?

For a change to move forward smoothly, it should include:

- Completed change request
- Required approvals (e.g., Director for Medium/High risk)
- Manifest information
- Supporting documentation (runbooks, diagrams, plans)

Incomplete submissions increase the risk of delay.

17. Why are senior leaders reviewing changes?

Leadership review provides **situational awareness and risk oversight**, not micromanagement. Leaders may intervene only if a change presents unacceptable operational risk, especially during freeze or elevated-risk periods.

18. Is leadership review an additional approval gate?

In most cases, it is **awareness and risk validation**, not a routine approval step. During freezes or heightened scrutiny, leadership may act as a final decision point.

19. Why are CAB meetings taking so long?

The volume of Medium and High-risk changes has increased significantly. Options being evaluated include:

- Additional CAB sessions
 - Expanded CAB membership
 - Improved precab or offline review to reduce meeting load
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20. Is there an offline or asynchronous CAB process?

Yes, but it is **exception-based** and not guaranteed. It is intended for urgent or late-breaking scenarios and should not replace planned CAB engagement.

21. Who should teams contact with questions or exceptions?

Teams should start with:

1. Their **manager and director**
2. The **IT Change Management** mailbox or team

Directors are accountable for helping teams navigate the process.

22. How will success be measured?

Success is not measured by paperwork volume. Key outcomes include:

- Reduced change-related incidents
 - Faster recovery when incidents occur
 - Improved predictability of deployments
 - Increased use of Standard Changes over time
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23. Will this process be revisited?

Yes. This is an **interim stability posture**, not a final state. The process will evolve based on:

- Operational outcomes
 - Data and metrics
 - Feedback from teams
 - Post-PSS readiness
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24. What is the core principle behind all of this?

Change Management is about keeping the airline safe, predictable, and reliable.

Guests never see our code—but they feel our discipline.